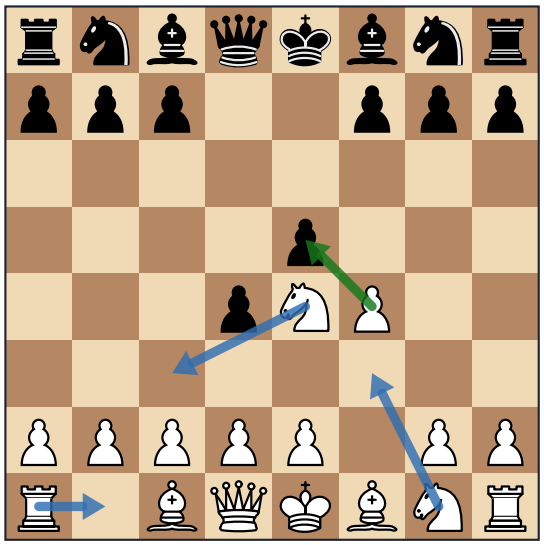
Van Geet Opening

ECO A00-C31 | 33 named lines | Flank openings (English, Reti, Bird, KIA)

In one sentence: Flexible flank openings control the center with pieces and avoid early theoretical battles.

Memory pattern: Fianchetto, control d5 and e5, then pick the center.



Main line: 1.Nc3 d5 2.f4 d4 3.Ne4 e5

Key ideas

1. Control d5 and e5 with pawns on c4 and pieces on f3 and c3.
2. Fianchetto the king's bishop (g3, Bg2) for long-diagonal pressure.
3. Choose a center after seeing Black's setup: d4 or e4.
4. Transpose to Queen's Gambit, Catalan or Sicilian-style structures.
5. English: reversed Sicilian ideas with extra tempo.

Reading the diagram

Blue arrows = thematic plan moves for the side to move. Green arrow = engine's best move.
Engine at the end of the main line: **-0.25** (slightly better for Black, depth 18). Best: fxe5.

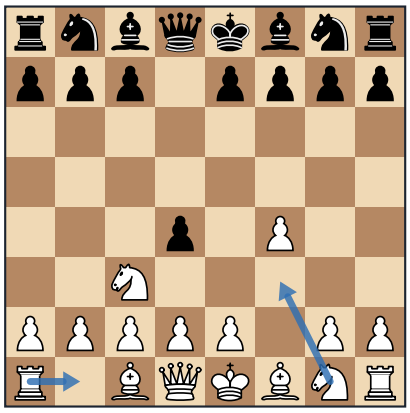
The five coach questions

1. Ideal pawn structure?	Control d5/e5 with pieces and keep the centre flexible (Reversed Sicilian, Reti, King's Indian Attack). Transpositions are common.
2. Where does my king go?	Castle short; g3/Bg2 is a safe shelter.
3. Best minor pieces?	Bg2 and Bb2 on the long diagonals, knights c3/f3, breaks with d4/e4.
4. Main middlegame plan?	Choose a centre after seeing Black's setup; expand with b4 or d4; attack with e4/Ne5.
5. What does my opponent want?	White wants a favourable centre; Black wants to claim the centre with ...e5/...d5 or symmetrical counterplay.

The main line, move by move

Most common continuation in the database: 1.Nc3 d5 2.f4 d4 3.Ne4 e5

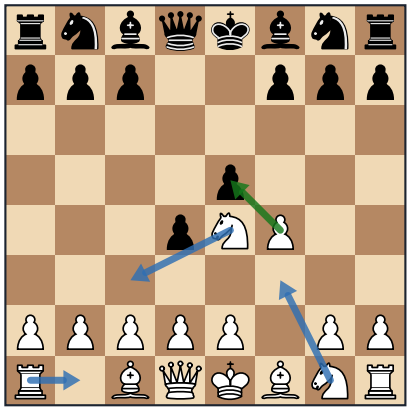
Move	Why it is played
1. Nc3	Develops the knight to c3.
1... d5	Hit c4. Occupies the center with a pawn.
2. f4	Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
2... d4	Occupies the center with a pawn.
3. Ne4	Repositions the knight to a more active square.
3... e5	Take the center. Occupies the center with a pawn.



After 1.Nc3 d5 2.f4 d4

Key variations

The most important named branches (ranked by how much theory lies beneath them). Diagram arrows: blue = plan moves, green = Stockfish.

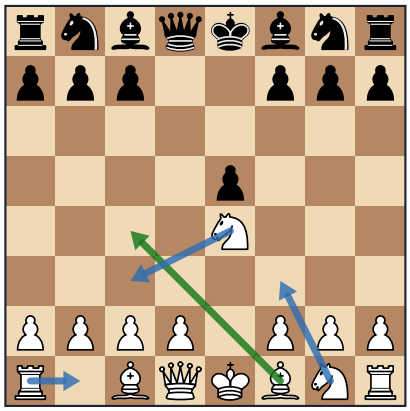


Position after the line

Pfeiffer Gambit A00 | 2 lines

`1.Nc3 d5 2.f4 d4 3.Ne4 e5`

Stockfish: **-0.18** (equal, depth 19). Best next move: fxe5.
What to look for: c4 (control d5); Nf3 (develop); g3 (fianchetto)
Sub-variations: Sleipnir Countergambit

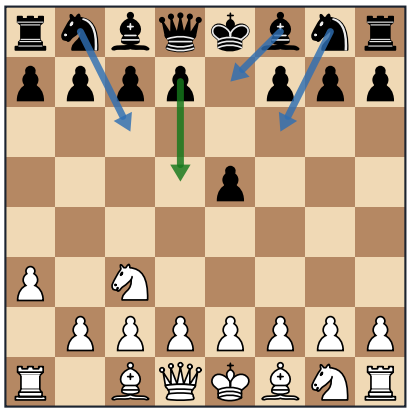


Position after the line

Grünfeld Defense B01 | 2 lines

`1.e4 d5 2.Nc3 dxe4 3.Nxe4 e5`

Stockfish: **+0.39** (slightly better for White, depth 15). Best next move: Bc4.
What to look for: c4 (control d5); Nf3 (develop); g3 (fianchetto)
Sub-variations: Steiner Gambit

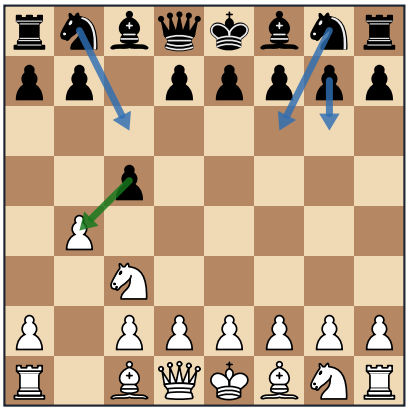


Position after the line

Battambang Variation A00 | 1 lines

`1.a3 e5 2.Nc3`

Stockfish: **-0.40** (slightly better for Black, depth 17). Best next move: d5.
What to look for: e5 (take the center); Nf6 (develop); d5 (hit c4)



Position after the line

Düsseldorf Gambit A00 | 1 lines

`1.Nc3 c5 2.b4`

Stockfish: **-1.26** (clearly better for Black, depth 19). Best next move: cxb4.
What to look for: e5 (take the center); Nf6 (develop); d5 (hit c4)

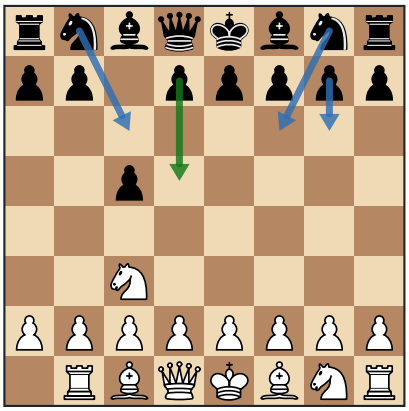


Position after the line

Myers Attack A00 | 1 lines

`1.Nc3 g6 2.h4`

Stockfish: **+0.06** (equal, depth 17). Best next move: d5.
What to look for: e5 (take the center); Nf6 (develop); d5 (hit c4)



Position after the line

Twyble Attack A00 | 1 lines

`1.Nc3 c5 2.Rb1`

Stockfish: **-0.61** (slightly better for Black, depth 15). Best next move: d5.
What to look for: e5 (take the center); Nf6 (develop); d5 (hit c4)

Expert and coach view

What a coach would tell you

Flank openings are about flexibility, not speed. Make sure you know the main transpositions and what structures you want, then choose moves accordingly.

Why play it

Flexible flank openings control the center with pieces and avoid early theoretical battles.

Typical mistakes

- Being too passive and letting Black take the center for free.
- Playing d3 and e4 without a plan for the queenside pawns.
- Neglecting development while chasing a fianchetto.

Typical tactics and traps

- Early Qb3 or Qa4 pins that win the c4 or d5 pawn if Black is careless.
- Tactics on the long diagonal against b7/g7.

Endgame and middlegame outlook

Balanced, flexible endgames with minor advantages for the better-placed bishops.

Study checklist

[ ] Play the main line on a board and say each move's purpose aloud.

[ ] Learn the five coach questions by heart; answer them without notes.

[ ] Drill two sub-variations until the moves feel automatic.

[ ] Play three games with the opening, then review where you left theory.

[ ] Re-read the traps page the day before a tournament.

The opening tree

Every named line in this family as a tree. Gray moves are inherited from the parent; green after the arrow are the new moves that define the variation. Large green dots mark branches with 10 or more lines.

- **Van Geet Opening (all lines)** — A00
  `1.Nc3`
  - **Laroche Gambit** — A00
    `1.Nc3 -> 1...b5`
  - **Reversed Nimzowitsch** — A00
    `1.Nc3 -> 1...e5`
  - **Battambang Variation** — A00
    `1.a3 e5 2.Nc3`
  - **Düsseldorf Gambit** — A00
    `1.Nc3 -> 1...c5 2.b4`
  - **Myers Attack** — A00
    `1.Nc3 -> 1...g6 2.h4`
  - **Twyble Attack** — A00
    `1.Nc3 -> 1...c5 2.Rb1`
  - **Tübingen Gambit** — A00
    `1.Nc3 -> 1...Nf6 2.g4`
  - **Billockus-Johansen Gambit** — A00
    `1.Nc3 -> 1...e5 2.Nf3 Bc5`
  - **Damhaug Gambit** — A00
    `1.Nc3 -> 1...d5 2.f4 e5`
  - **Warsteiner Gambit** — A00
    `1.Nc3 -> 1...d5 2.f4 g5`
  - **Dougherty Gambit** — A00
    `1.Nc3 -> 1...d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.f3`
  - **Dunst-Perrenet Gambit** — A00
    `1.Nc3 -> 1...d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.d3`
  - **Hector Gambit** — A00
    `1.Nc3 -> 1...d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Bc4`
  - **Kluever Gambit** — A00
    `1.Nc3 -> 1...f5 2.e4 fxe4 3.d3`
  - **Napoleon Attack** — A00
    `1.Nc3 -> 1...e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4`
  - **Nowokunski Gambit** — A00
    `1.Nc3 -> 1...e5 2.f4 exf4 3.e4`
  - **Venezolana Variation** — A00
    `1.Nc3 -> 1...d5 2.d3 Nf6 3.g3`
  - **Grünfeld Defense** — B01
    `1.e4 d5 2.Nc3 dxe4 3.Nxe4 e5`
    - **Steiner Gambit** — C31
      `1.e4 e5 2.f4 d5 3.Nc3 dxe4 4.Nxe4`
  - **Hergert Gambit** — A00
    `1.Nc3 -> 1...d6 2.f4 e5 3.fxe5 Nc6`
  - **Hulsemann Gambit** — A00
    `1.Nc3 -> 1...e5 2.e3 d5 3.Qh5 Be6`
  - **Liebig Gambit** — A00
    `1.Nc3 -> 1...e5 2.e3 d5 3.Qh5 Nf6`
  - **Melleby Gambit** — A00
    `1.Nc3 -> 1...d5 2.f4 d4 3.Ne4 c5`
  - **Pfeiffer Gambit** — A00
    `1.Nc3 -> 1...d5 2.f4 d4 3.Ne4 e5`
    - **Sleipnir Countergambit** — A00
      `1.Nc3 d5 2.f4 d4 3.Ne4 e5 -> 4.Nf3`
  - **Sleipnir Gambit** — A00
    `1.Nc3 -> 1...d5 2.e3 e5 3.d4 Bb4`
  - **Berlin Gambit** — B00
    `1.e4 Nc6 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 dxe4 4.d5`
  - **Gladbacher Gambit** — A00
    `1.Nc3 -> 1...e5 2.b3 d5 3.e4 dxe4 4.d3`

Novosibirsk Variation A00
1.Nc3 -> 1...c5 2.d4 cxd4 3.Qxd4 Nc6 4.Qh4

Reversed Scandinavian A00
1.Nc3 -> 1...e5 2.d4 exd4 3.Qxd4 Nc6 4.Qa4

Sicilian Two Knights A00
1.Nc3 -> 1...c5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 cxd4 4.Nxd4

Jendrossek Gambit A00
1.Nc3 -> 1...d5 2.f4 d4 3.Ne4 f5 4.Nf2 Nf6 5.Nf3 c5 6.b4

One-page memory sheet

Move-order pattern

```
1.Nc3 d5 2.f4 d4 3.Ne4 e5
```

Plan chain

White	c4 -> Nf3 -> g3 -> Bg2 -> O-O
Black	e5 -> Nf6 -> d5 -> c5 -> g6

Three rules to remember

1. Fianchetto, control d5 and e5, then pick the center.
2. Choose a centre after seeing Black's setup; expand with b4 or d4; attack with e4/Ne5.
3. White wants a favourable centre; Black wants to claim the centre with ...e5/...d5 or symmetrical counterplay.

Pawn structure in one line

Control d5/e5 with pieces and keep the centre flexible (Reversed Sicilian, Reti, King's Indian Attack). Transpositions are common.